

Consider your decision to come to Notre Dame. Here is one way

things could have gone:

Would the fact that the brain event occurred 300ms before
the conscious awareness make your decision unfree?

The decision

You consciously thought about it for a long time. You weighed the pros (great academic reputation, football, wonderful philosophy professors) and the cons (weather, the university theology requirement). Finally, after months of stewing, you decided to come to Notre Dame.

That decision involved a brain event and a conscious awareness of the decision. The brain event (RP-onset) occurred about 300ms before the conscious awareness.



replies to
Libet

A large, solid red circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the Libet experiments" is written in a white, sans-serif font, centered both horizontally and vertically.

the Libet
experiments



is free will
an important
good?

Suppose first that you think that free will is compatible with determinism. Then it seems that you should not find the fact (if it is a fact) that your action was caused by brain events which precede conscious willing especially threatening to free will.

Suppose instead that you think that free will is incompatible with determinism. Then Libet's results might seem more threatening. But even then, it might be that the brain events recorded at RP-onset in a complex decision like this one are the results of prior thoughts and decisions which were themselves undetermined. Then the illusion is not about **whether** we have free will, but **when** the free choice happened. Sometimes, on this view, what seems like the making of a free decision might instead be the realization that you have already freely decided.

things could have gone:



Consider your decision to name. Here is one way



Would the fact that the brain evolved 300ms before

are we conscious of our decisions?



You consciously thought about it for a long time. You

awareness of the decision. The brain event (RP-onset)

weighed the pros (great academic reputation, football,

months of stewing, you decided to Notre Dame.

That decision involved a fair and sound

wonderful philosophy professors) and the cons (whether,

the university technology requirement). Finally, after

occurred about 300ms before the decision was made.



Therapeutic
disinfection



replies to
Libet

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will prosper by contemporary neuroscience.

In ancient times, philosophers worried about the challenge to free will from fate. After

the birth of modern physics, many worried about the challenges it would bring from

determinism. Our topic today is much more recent challenge to free











